

of stardust? Not really. Not in a year that saw a record number of debuts of actors, directors, even producers showing what they were capable of.

But as Bollywood got rooted in reality, it also got a taste of realty.

Movies moved from mansions set in Neverland to narratives based in specific cities, with the ultimate valentine to amchi Mumbai—its slums, its trains, its much abused spirit—coming from *Slumdog Millionaire*, Hollywood's darling *du jour*. India is at the centre of the world, crowed Jamal's brother to him as they surveyed the city from a half-completed building. It certainly looked like it when Reliance Entertainment stepped in after Dreamworks and Paramount split in acrimony, and even though the recession looked like hiving off some of the \$1.2-billion deal, it was undeniable that the world's most commercially successful director had been bailed out by an Indian mogul's

money. It looked like India had finally made a mark on Hollywood—via England—after years of trying, from Shekhar Kapur's Elizabethan romps to Aishwarya Rai's blink-and-misses. But the man who was truly on the cusp of going international stayed away from the limelight, working late into the night in his shack outside Chennai, plucking symphonies out of nothing. Allah Rakha Rahman, after a decade of trying to make Bollywood accept his high standards, simply found takers in the West, with much the same chutzpah that Jamal got on to *Who Wants to Be a Millionaire*.

It was a fairytale of rags to raja that everyone needed, and it wasn't made in India. Perhaps there was a lesson in it. As Indian money went global, global creativity had to tell the India story. Perhaps India was too busy grappling with its too-muchness of reality. In a year when we faced uncompromising evil and saw



IPL SEASON 2: Shah Rukh Khan's glossy posse, and the cheerleaders, covered up or not. We couldn't wait to get started again.

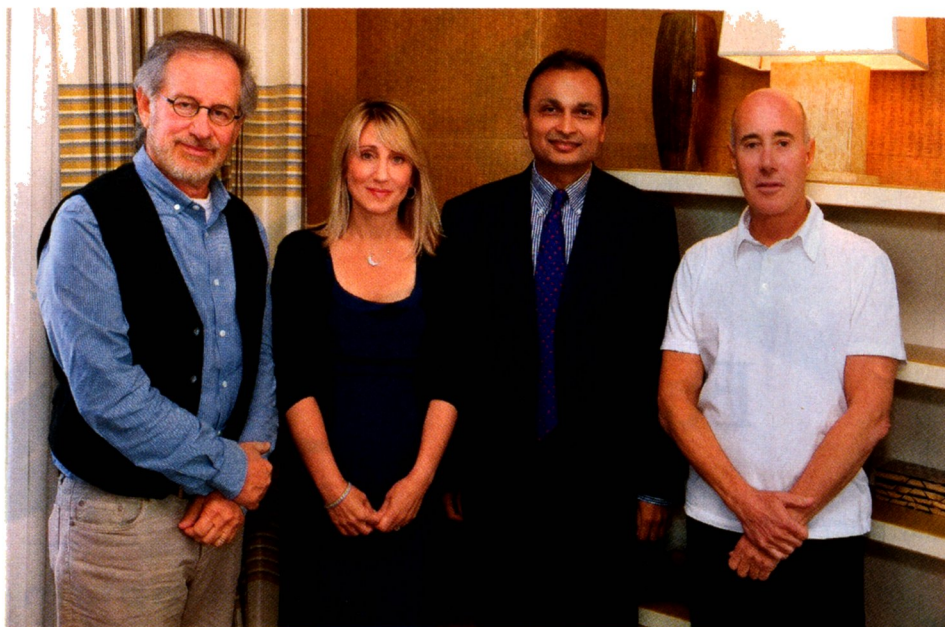
HEROES REDUX: Shah Rukh in *Billu Barber*, Aamir Khan in *3 Idiots* and Akshay Kumar in everything else. Stars are baaaaack!

YOUNG TURKS: Imtiaz Ali, Anurag Basu, Mohit Suri. Bollywood's promising second line of directorial talent would be back with new films.

CAPITAL CITY: If 2008 was the year of the Maximum City, 2009 may well just belong to Delhi: From Chandni Chowk to China and Delhi 6.

Things to Look Forward to

(FROM LEFT) STEVEN SPIELBERG, STACY SNIDER, ANIL AMBANI AND DAVID GEFEN AFTER THE DREAMWORKS DEAL



RALPH ALSWANG

heroism from close quarters, it wasn't odd that our fantasies could not keep pace with history as it unfolded. If all the villains strode the streets of Mumbai, Delhi, Bangalore, Ahmedabad and Jaipur, then the heroes too were in our homes, not on our screens. What could compete with the horror of a 100-year-old hotel, built by a creator of modern India as a retort to imperialism, in flames? Or its historic commuter nerve centre, a colonial edifice encapsulating a bustling contemporary city, being brought to a standstill? In the twilight of capitalism and the dawn of living with everyday terror, wasn't it fitting that entertainment could not deliver us? Only remind us of the way we are? As Aravind Adiga's feral *White Tiger* did? ■